

PSAT/NMSQT

High-Yield 30

30 High-Yield Questions Weighted to the Real Digital PSAT/NMSQT Blueprint

Reading & Writing • Math • Full Answer Explanations

Exclusive bonus for readers of the PSAT/NMSQT Study Guide

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How This Bonus Was Built

These 30 questions are not a random sample. They are weighted to approximate the real digital PSAT/NMSQT section proportions: the official test splits its 98 questions 54 Reading & Writing to 44 Math, so this bonus mirrors that with 17 Reading & Writing questions and 13 Math questions.

Within Reading & Writing, the question types reflect the four official domains — Craft and Structure, Information and Ideas, Standard English Conventions, and Expression of Ideas. Within Math, the four official domains are covered too — Algebra, Advanced Math, Problem-Solving and Data Analysis, and Geometry and Trigonometry.

Every question below includes a full explanation: why the correct answer is right, and why each of the other choices is wrong. That second part is what most practice sets skip — and it's usually where the actual learning happens.

Reading and Writing

Question 1 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: Restoration ecologists had long assumed that a burned forest needs decades to recover its full range of species, but new survey data reveal a striking _____: within just five years, understory plant diversity in the burn zone matched levels found in untouched stands nearby.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. decline
- B. anomaly
- C. consensus
- D. delay

Correct Answer: B

"Anomaly" (choice B) matches a surprising deviation from the expected slow-recovery pattern — five years matching untouched levels is unexpected. "Decline" (A) contradicts the positive recovery described. "Consensus" (C) and "delay" (D) don't fit a finding that contradicts prior assumptions.

Question 2 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: Although the internship paid nothing, Dana described the experience as _____, citing the mentorship and hands-on skills she gained as worth far more than a paycheck.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. worthless
- B. ordinary
- C. brief
- D. invaluable

Correct Answer: D

"Invaluable" (choice D) matches "worth far more than a paycheck" — despite no pay, she valued it highly. "Worthless" (A) is the opposite. "Ordinary" (B) and "brief" (C) don't connect to the mentorship/skills reasoning given.

Question 3 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: A city debated banning plastic bags at grocery stores. Some small business owners worried about extra costs for reusable alternatives. The city council responded by pointing to a neighboring city where a similar ban led retailers to report a 10% drop in packaging expenses within a year.

Which choice best describes the function of the last sentence in the passage?

- A. It offers evidence intended to ease the business owners' concern.
- B. It undermines the ban by revealing a hidden cost.
- C. It shifts the discussion to an unrelated policy.
- D. It repeats the business owners' worry in different words.

Correct Answer: A

The last sentence provides real data (a drop in packaging expenses elsewhere) that responds directly to business owners' worry about extra costs — evidence addressing their concern (choice A). It doesn't undermine the ban (B; no hidden cost is revealed), doesn't shift topics (C), and doesn't just restate the worry (D) — it answers it.

Question 4 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: The documentary opens with a close-up interview of a single factory worker describing a shift change, then widens to show the entire plant's production line, and finally cuts to national employment statistics tied to the manufacturing sector.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the documentary?

- A. It compares two competing factories.
- B. It repeats one scene for dramatic effect.
- C. It moves from one worker's experience to the plant and then to national statistics.
- D. It moves from national statistics down to one worker's experience.

Correct Answer: C

The documentary explicitly widens from one worker, to the plant, to national statistics — specific to broad (choice C). Choice D reverses this order. Choices A and B describe structures (comparison, repetition) that don't match the description.

Question 5 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: A 2025 study tracked 600 office workers who began taking short walking breaks every 90 minutes. Researchers measured self-reported focus levels before and after adopting the habit. On average, participants reported an 18% improvement in focus within three weeks, though the improvement was smaller among workers whose jobs required frequent video calls.

Which choice best states the main finding of the study?

- A. Walking breaks always improve focus, regardless of job type.
- B. Workers who take frequent video calls never improve their focus.
- C. The study found no link between walking breaks and focus.
- D. Walking breaks were associated with improved focus, though frequent video calls lessened the effect.

Correct Answer: D

Choice D captures the whole finding: an association between walking breaks and improved focus, plus the qualifier that video calls weakened it. Choice A overstates with "always" and "regardless." Choice B claims something absolute the passage never says. Choice C contradicts the reported 18% improvement.

Question 6 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: Urban rooftop farms occupy a tiny fraction of a city's total land area, yet a recent audit found they supply a disproportionately large share of the leafy greens sold at nearby farmers markets. This makes them a valuable piece of local food systems despite their limited footprint.

According to the passage, why are urban rooftop farms considered valuable to local food systems?

- A. Because they cover most of the city's available land.
- B. Because they produce a large share of food relative to their small size.
- C. Because they are the only source of leafy greens in the city.
- D. Because their small size makes them easy to regulate.

Correct Answer: B

The passage's key contrast is small land use vs. large output — that disproportion is why they're valuable (choice B). Choice A is factually wrong. Choice C overstates with "only." Choice D isn't discussed in the passage.

Question 7 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A trainer claims that athletes who stretch before AND after practice recover faster than athletes who only stretch before. In a team study, one group of 24 athletes stretched both before and after practice and reported average soreness scores of 3.2 out of 10 the next day, while another group of 24 who stretched only before reported average soreness scores of 5.6.

Which choice best supports the trainer's claim?

- A. The before-and-after group's average soreness (3.2) was lower than the before-only group's average (5.6).
- B. Both groups had exactly 24 athletes.
- C. All athletes practiced on the same field.
- D. The study lasted one season.

Correct Answer: A

The claim compares recovery, so the relevant evidence is the soreness-score gap between groups — 3.2 vs. 5.6 directly supports it (choice A). Choices B, C, and D describe equal/neutral conditions that make the comparison fair but don't by themselves prove one method worked better.

Question 8 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A gym manager argues that a new class-booking app reduced no-shows. No-shows dropped from 18 per week to 9 per week after the app launched. During the same period, the gym also began charging a small late-cancellation fee.

Which choice best describes a weakness in using this data to support the manager's claim?

- A. The no-show numbers were not collected at the same gym.
- B. The sample of members was too small to matter.
- C. A second change (the cancellation fee) happened at the same time, so the drop can't be credited to the app alone.
- D. No-shows actually increased after the app launched.

Correct Answer: C

Because the cancellation fee began during the same period, the drop in no-shows could be caused by either change — the data alone can't isolate the app's effect (choice C). Choices A and D are factually wrong per the passage. Choice B isn't addressed by the passage at all.

Question 9 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The lab has a specimen archive _____ researchers can request samples for approved studies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. were
- B. where
- C. we're
- D. where,

Correct Answer: B

"Where" (choice B) correctly introduces a clause describing the archive (a place). "Were" (A) and "we're" (C) are homophones that don't fit grammatically. Choice D adds an unnecessary comma separating the clause from what it describes.

Question 10 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The row of display cases, restored by volunteers over the past three summers, _____ located just inside the museum's main entrance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. is
- B. are
- C. were
- D. have been

Correct Answer: A

The subject is "the row" (singular), not "cases" or "summers," which sit inside a modifying phrase. A singular subject takes "is" (choice A). The other choices agree with a plural noun instead of the true subject.

Question 11 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: By the time the ceremony ended, the two _____ medals had already been polished and displayed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. winner's
- B. winners's
- C. winners
- D. winners'

Correct Answer: D

"Winners'" (choice D) is the correct plural possessive — there are two winners, so the apostrophe goes after the "s." Choice A is singular possessive. Choice B isn't a standard form. Choice C has no apostrophe, leaving "medals" without an owner.

Question 12 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: Originally designed as a warehouse, the developers eventually converted the building into loft apartments.

Which choice best revises the sentence to correct a misplaced modifier?

- A. Originally designed as a warehouse, loft apartments eventually came from the developers converting the building.
- B. The developers, originally designed as a warehouse, eventually converted the building into loft apartments.
- C. Originally designed as a warehouse, the building was eventually converted by the developers into loft apartments.
- D. No change is needed.

Correct Answer: C

"Originally designed as a warehouse" describes the building, not the developers, so "the building" must follow the comma — only choice C does this. The original sentence (and choice B) wrongly implies the developers were "originally designed as a warehouse." Choice A still doesn't place "the building" right after the modifier.

Question 13 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The observatory's main telescope, which astronomers consider the most precise instrument on site _____ has tracked the same comet for over a decade.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. ,
- B. ;
- C. .
- D. (no punctuation)

Correct Answer: A

"Which astronomers consider the most precise instrument on site" is nonessential information inserted into the main sentence, so it needs a comma on both sides. Since it already opens with a comma, it must close with one too (choice A). Ending with a semicolon, period, or nothing (choices B, C, D) breaks the sentence's grammar.

Question 14 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: The community pool reopened two weeks ahead of schedule. _____, membership renewals rose by 15% that same month.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. However

- B. Additionally
- C. For example
- D. In contrast

Correct Answer: B

Both sentences describe positive facts about the same event, so "Additionally" (choice B) correctly adds a second positive fact. "However" (A) and "In contrast" (D) wrongly suggest a contradiction. "For example" (C) wrongly implies the renewal fact is an instance of the reopening fact.

Question 15 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: Many commuters struggle to stay alert during long train rides. Brief standing stretches every 20 minutes, _____, can noticeably reduce fatigue.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for instance
- B. in other words
- C. therefore
- D. commuters report

Correct Answer: D

"Commuters report" (choice D) works as a parenthetical attribution, making the sentence read naturally as a claim attributed to a source rather than a stated fact. "For instance" (A) and "in other words" (B) don't fit that slot. "Therefore" (C) would need an established cause, which the text doesn't provide.

Question 16 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- A school's robotics club recruited 45 new members last year.
- The club operates on a budget funded entirely by bake sales, with no school funding.

The student wants to emphasize how the club achieved strong growth with minimal resources.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The robotics club recruited members last year, and it holds bake sales.
- B. The robotics club recruited 45 members last year, and it has no school funding.
- C. Despite operating on a budget funded entirely by bake sales, the club recruited 45 new members last year.
- D. Last year was a strong year for the club, which grew a lot.

Correct Answer: C

Choice C directly connects the minimal resources (bake-sale funding only, no school funding) to the strong growth (45 members) with "despite" — exactly the emphasis wanted. Choice B lists both facts without that framing. Choice A omits the specific number. Choice D is vague and drops the funding detail.

Question 17 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- *A neighborhood tool-lending library loaned out equipment 900 times in its first year.*
- *A survey found that residents who borrowed tools reported completing more home repair projects.*

The student wants to present the connection between the tool library and residents completing more projects.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A.** After the tool-lending library loaned out equipment 900 times, residents who borrowed reported completing more home repair projects.
- B.** Tool libraries are a growing trend in many cities.
- C.** The tool-lending library loaned out equipment 900 times in its first year.
- D.** A survey found that residents reported completing more home repair projects.

Correct Answer: A

Choice A links both facts in one connected statement — the loans, then the resulting survey finding — exactly the connection wanted. Choices C and D each state only one fact alone. Choice B is a general claim not drawn from the notes.

Math

Question 18 | Algebra

If $4x - 7 = x + 8$, what is the value of x ?

- A. 3
- B. 5
- C. 7
- D. 9

Correct Answer: B

$4x - 7 = x + 8 \rightarrow 4x - x = 8 + 7 \rightarrow 3x = 15 \rightarrow x = 5$ (choice B). Choice A would come from a sign error; choices C and D don't satisfy the equation.

Question 19 | Algebra

The system of equations $3x + y = 14$ and $x - y = 2$ has solution (x, y) . What is the value of $x + y$?

- A. 5
- B. 7
- C. 9
- D. 6

Correct Answer: D

Adding the equations eliminates y : $(3x + y) + (x - y) = 14 + 2 \rightarrow 4x = 16 \rightarrow x = 4$. From $x - y = 2$, $y = 2$. So $x + y = 4 + 2 = 6$ (choice D). Choices A, B, and C don't satisfy both original equations.

Question 20 | Algebra

A rental car costs \$40 for the first day and \$25 for each additional day. If Elena has at most \$190 to spend, what is the maximum number of whole days she can rent the car?

- A. 5
- B. 6
- C. 7
- D. 8

Correct Answer: C

The cost for d days ($d \geq 1$) is $40 + 25(d - 1)$. Setting $40 + 25(d - 1) \leq 190$ gives $25(d - 1) \leq 150$, so $d - 1 \leq 6$ and $d \leq 7$ (choice C). At $d = 7$ the cost is exactly \$190; at $d = 8$ (choice D) it would be \$215, over budget.

Question 21 | Advanced Math

What are the solutions to $x^2 + 2x - 15 = 0$?

- A. $x = -5$ and $x = 3$

- B. $x = 5$ and $x = -3$
- C. $x = -5$ and $x = -3$
- D. $x = 5$ and $x = 3$

Correct Answer: A

$x^2 + 2x - 15$ factors as $(x + 5)(x - 3)$, since $5 \times (-3) = -15$ and $5 + (-3) = 2$. Setting each factor to zero gives $x = -5$ and $x = 3$ (choice A). The other choices come from sign errors made while factoring.

Question 22 | Advanced Math

For $x > 0$, $(x^{(3/5)})^5 = x^k$. What is the value of k ?

- A. 8
- B. 15
- C. $5/3$
- D. 3

Correct Answer: D

Raising a power to a power multiplies the exponents: $(3/5) \times 5 = 3$ (choice D). Choice A comes from adding the numerator and the outer exponent incorrectly; choice B comes from multiplying 3×5 instead of $(3/5) \times 5$; choice C comes from dividing instead of multiplying.

Question 23 | Advanced Math

The function $f(x) = 2(x + 4)^2 - 5$. What is $f(-1)$?

- A. 7
- B. 13
- C. 11
- D. 23

Correct Answer: B

$f(-1) = 2(-1 + 4)^2 - 5 = 2(3)^2 - 5 = 2(9) - 5 = 18 - 5 = 13$ (choice B). Choice A would come from an arithmetic slip inside the parentheses; choices C and D come from other order-of-operations errors.

Question 24 | Advanced Math

For $P(x) = 2x^2 + 3x - 1$, what is the remainder when $P(x)$ is divided by $(x - 3)$?

- A. 20
- B. 14
- C. 26
- D. 8

Correct Answer: C

By the Remainder Theorem, the remainder when $P(x)$ is divided by $(x - 3)$ equals $P(3)$: $2(3)^2 + 3(3) - 1 = 18 + 9 - 1 = 26$ (choice C). The other choices come from arithmetic slips evaluating $P(3)$.

Question 25 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

A tablet's price was reduced from \$250 to \$200. By what percent was the price reduced?

- A. 25%
- B. 15%
- C. 30%
- D. 20%

Correct Answer: D

The dollar decrease is $\$250 - \$200 = \$50$. As a percent of the original price: $50/250 = 0.20 = 20\%$ (choice D). Choices A, B, and C come from dividing by the wrong base or misreading the dollar amount as the percent.

Question 26 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

In a random sample of 220 commuters, 132 said they use public transit. Based on this sample, how many commuters out of a population of 1,100 would be expected to use public transit?

- A. 660
- B. 600
- C. 720
- D. 550

Correct Answer: A

The sample proportion is $132/220 = 3/5$. Applying that proportion to 1,100 commuters: $1,100 \times 3/5 = 660$ (choice A). Choice B would come from using $6/11$ instead of $3/5$; choices C and D come from other proportion errors.

Question 27 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

Six students scored 55, 82, 91, 68, 77, and 84 on an exam. What is the median score?

- A. 77
- B. 82
- C. 79.5
- D. 80

Correct Answer: C

Sorting the scores gives 55, 68, 77, 82, 84, 91. With six values, the median is the average of the two middle values (3rd and 4th): $(77 + 82)/2 = 79.5$ (choice C). The other choices are individual scores or other miscalculations, not the median.

Question 28 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A right triangle has legs of length 10 and 24. What is its area?

- A. 240
- B. 120

C. 34

D. 68

Correct Answer: B

The area of a right triangle is half the product of its two legs: $(1/2)(10)(24) = 120$ (choice B). Choice A omits the factor of $1/2$. Choices C and D resemble the perimeter or half the perimeter, not the area.

Question 29 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A circle has a diameter of 18. What is its area, in terms of π ?

A. 18π

B. 36π

C. 162π

D. 81π

Correct Answer: D

The radius is half the diameter: $18/2 = 9$. Area = $\pi r^2 = \pi(9)^2 = 81\pi$ (choice D). Choice A confuses diameter with area. Choice C uses the diameter squared incorrectly. Choice B doubles the radius instead of squaring it.

Question 30 | Geometry and Trigonometry

In right triangle DEF, angle F is the right angle, side DE (the hypotenuse) has length 13, and side EF (opposite angle D) has length 5. What is $\cos(D)$?

A. $12/13$

B. $5/13$

C. $13/12$

D. $13/5$

Correct Answer: A

$\cos(D)$ is the ratio of the side adjacent to angle D to the hypotenuse. The side adjacent to D is $DF = \sqrt{13^2 - 5^2} = \sqrt{144} = 12$, so $\cos(D) = 12/13$ (choice A). Choice B ($5/13$) would be $\sin(D)$, using the opposite side over the hypotenuse. Choices C and D invert the correct ratios.